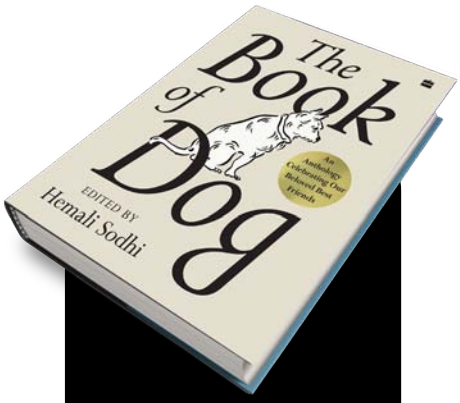


THE BOOK OF DOG
edited by Hemali Sodhi
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699; 336 pages

CAT PEOPLE
edited by Devapriya Roy
SIMON & SCHUSTER INDIA
₹499; 295 pages



fiction while *The Book of Dog* (*DOG*) is almost entirely first-person documentary. In both books, there are many instances of aliases and initials being used in the place of complete names. Perhaps a sign of the number of famous people who appear at centre-stage or in the wings?

There are more stories in *DOG*, but most are only a few pages long. *CAT* has fewer but longer pieces and the love described within them is both more piercing and mysterious. As Vangmayi Parakala tells us in her self-reflective story 'Seventy Per Cent Cat', the Mahabharata records Yudhistira's friendship with a dog, but there are no references to cat-human companionships in either of the major myth-cycles. There's an image of a cat in yogic pose, she writes, in the huge bas-relief called 'Bhageeratha's Penance' at Mahabalipuram, but its story is one of feline treachery.

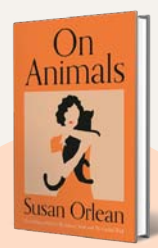
Jai Arjun Singh's essay 'Through the Sands of Time' in *CAT* is exceptional, both in the way that it's told as well as for the many shades of pathos it contains. His piece 'Part-Time Dogs' provides an emotional hinge that connects both books. The place of non-humans is precarious even at the best of times, but, as he shows us in both his pieces, the pandemic was exceptionally harsh for street animals. The closing of roadside eateries in cities meant that the creatures who depended on them for handouts were left to die of starvation and thirst.

Unlike any similar tales of furry and bewhiskered companions in the industrialised world, the sagas of companion-creatures in India often include the shadowy presence of domestic 'helps': cooks, maids, *dhobis*, drivers, security guards and others. In these stories, where many of the non-humans are named and adored, these others are referred to only in passing, frequently unnamed and undescribed. In this sense, both books provide an unintended double narrative. The dominant one is about the much-beloved non-humans with their wet noses, wagging tails, hisses and purrs. The hidden one is about the many humans who attend upon those who write essays about their pets.

DOG contains more overtly humorous stories than *CAT*. My favourite is the very first one, by Ashok Ferrey, 'The Average Sri Lankan Family', concerning the gradual colonisation of a human home by canny canines. Many stories are deeply personal, involving tragedies and breakdowns. One that I liked for the way that it maintained narrative tension between the dogs and the author's nerves is 'Death, Dignity, Dogs'. Maneka Gandhi's 'Why Do We Go Looking for Children of the Heart?' is achingly sad. Both photo essays are wonderful—Divya Duggar's 'Chaos in a Coupe' and Sooni Taraporevala's 'The Dogs of Marine Drive'—leading one to hope that there will be many wonderful photo-albums to follow. ■

–Manjula Padmanabhan

THE STORIES ARE WRITTEN BY PEOPLE WHOSE LIVES HAVE BEEN FUNDAMENTALLY ALTERED BY THE SOMETIMES ABSURD BUT OFTEN UNBEARABLE SWEETNESS OF FURRY, FOUR-FOOTED CREATURES



ON ANIMALS
by Susan Orlean
ATLANTIC BOOKS
₹699; 256 pages

Always generous and sometimes humorous, Susan Orlean's essays focus on the birds and mammals–turkeys, cattle, chickens, dogs–that have been residents and guests at her farm in upstate New York.



PUG ACTUALLY
by Matt Dunn
MIRA BOOKS
₹550; 320 pages

Narrated by Doug, a loyal rescue pug, this hilarious novel offers laughs and comfort in equal measure. Though confounded by human relationships, Doug tries hard to bring together his owner and his vet.